Radium, the only radioactive **alkaline earth metal**, was discovered by **Marie and Pierre Curie** in 1898.

More metals

Most of the elements known to us are metals. In addition to the transition metals, there are five other metal groups in the periodic table, featuring a wide range of properties.

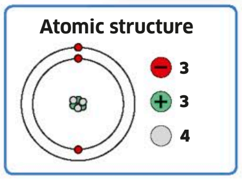
The alkali metals and alkaline earth metals are soft, shiny, and very reactive. The elements known as “other metals” are less reactive and have lower melting points. Underneath the transition metals are the lanthanides, which used to be called “rare earth metals,” but turned out not to be rare at all, and the radioactive actinides. Whatever the group, these metals are all malleable, and good conductors of electricity and heat.

LITHIUM

Lithium

Discovered: 1817

3 6.941 Li LITHIUM



Lithium is the lightest of all metals. It has been used in alloys in the construction of spacecraft. In more familiar uses, we find lithium in batteries, and also in compounds used to make medicines.

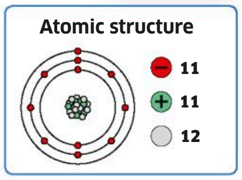
Pure lithium is a soft, silver-colored metal.

SODIUM

Natrium

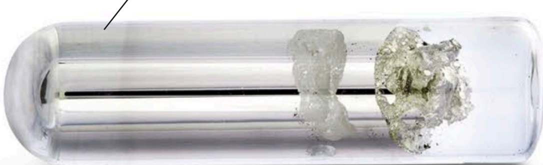
Discovered: 1807

11 22.990 Na SODIUM



So soft it can easily be cut with a knife and very reactive, sodium is more familiar to us when in compounds such as common salt (sodium chloride). It is essential for life, and plays a vital role in our bodies.

Sodium is so reactive it needs to be stored away from air in sealed vials.

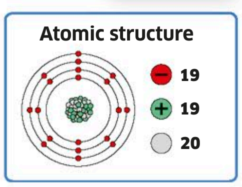


POTASSIUM

Kalium

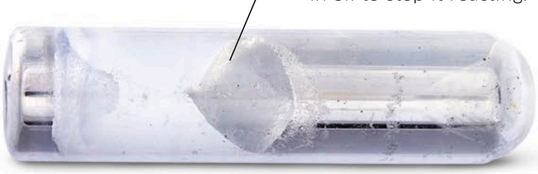
Discovered: 1807

19 39.098 K POTASSIUM



Along with sodium, the alkali metal potassium helps to control the nervous system in our bodies. We get it from foods such as bananas, avocados, and coconut water. It is added to fertilizers and is also part of a compound used in gunpowder.

Highly reactive, potassium is often stored in oil to stop it reacting.

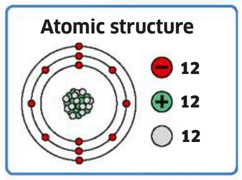


MAGNESIUM

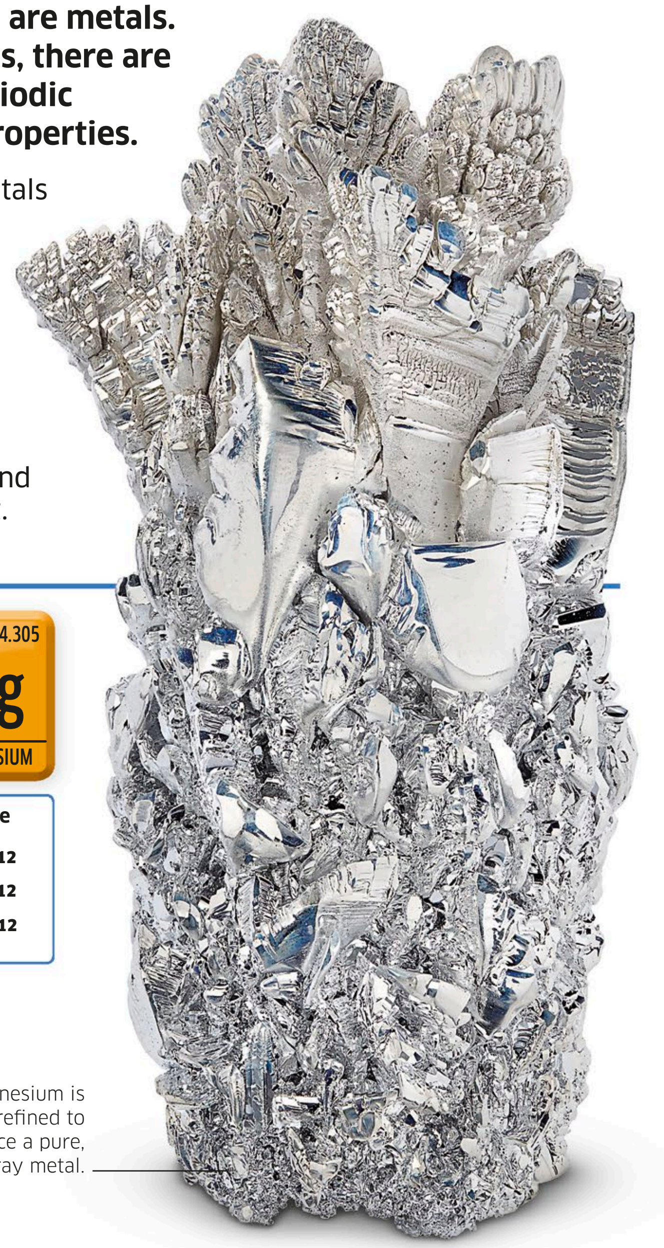
Magnesium

Discovered: 1755

12 24.305 Mg MAGNESIUM



Magnesium is an important metal because it is both strong and light in weight. The oceans are a main source of magnesium, but it’s quite expensive to produce, so recycling it is crucial. As a powder, or thin strip, it is flammable and burns with a bright white light. It is often used in fireworks and flares.



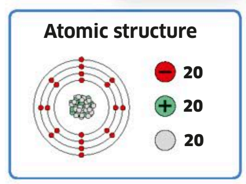
Magnesium is refined to produce a pure, shiny gray metal.

CALCIUM

Calcium

Discovered: 1808

20 40.078 Ca CALCIUM



Our bodies are full of calcium, the fifth most common element on Earth. It makes teeth and bones strong, which is why it is important to eat calcium-rich foods, such as broccoli and oranges. It is also a vital part of compounds used to make cement and plaster.

Pure metal samples such as this one are prepared using chemical processes. In nature, calcium is part of many minerals, but it doesn’t exist on its own.